

THE DAUGHTERS OF THE Republic

ANCIENT ROME

The Roman Republic, which lasted from 509 BCE to 27 BCE, ascribed little value to women, who lived under the authority of male guardians—their father or their husband. At birth, men and women alike had a short average life expectancy of about 30 years, but people often lived into their sixties if they survived childhood. Girls usually married in their teens, and had to remain chaste until then, but after marriage they were expected to produce children. Roman women inhabited a domestic sphere; they were responsible for running the household and taking care of the family—all the while staying modest and loyal towards their husbands.

Roman marriage

There were two types of marriage in ancient Rome, known as *cum manu* and *sine manu*. The difference between the two depended on who would act as the woman's guardian. In a *cum manu* marriage, the wife and her property came under her husband's legal control, whereas in a *sine manu* marriage, the wife remained under her father's guardianship. *Sine manu* marriages emerged at the end of the

Republic and became more common in the Empire (see pp. 38–39).

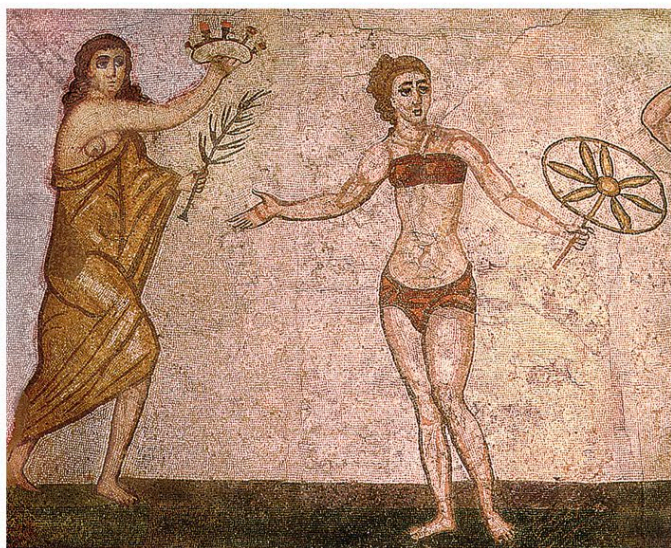
Marriages among the elites were often political alliances, and it was

customary for the bride's family to pay a dowry—which might include land, slaves, clothes, toiletries, and jewelry. The dowry provided for the marriage, and often included items ensuring that the woman remained beautiful and well-dressed. A dowry was traditionally recognized as a woman's property, and so returned to her family in the case of divorce (a common practice among the ancient Romans, and an equal right among men and women), and it was hers to pass on after death as she chose.

Vowed to Vesta

The Vestal Virgins' lives were in stark contrast to those of other Roman women. Vestals were priestesses of the cult of Vesta—virgin goddess of the home and hearth—and it was considered a high honour to be a Vestal Virgin. Rome's chief priest, the *pontifex maximus*, selected them. He chose noble girls between the ages of six and ten. Service lasted for 30 years, the first ten of which were spent learning their duties. Six maidens were granted the responsibility of tending to the sacred fire of Vesta and ensuring that it never burned out. The fire was symbolic of Rome and its existence, and Romans believed that if it went out, it would have disastrous consequences for all aspects of life. Vestals were therefore punished harshly if they neglected their duties.

Sworn to chastity, vestals symbolized the purity of Rome. A priestess who



◀ Sports for all

Although ancient Rome is not associated with women's freedom, this 4th-century mosaic of a female athlete being crowned suggests that women did have opportunities to engage in sports.

